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Where Did the Kwangdae Come From?

Until urbanization and modern mass communications altered the traditional balance, popular literary cultures existed alongside, but distinguished from, the higher cultures of the same peoples of East Asia. In China, for example, the formal, written literature of the gentry had long been distinguished from its oral (and orally derived), popular counterparts, not only by content and style but by language as well. Indeed, neither the spoken language nor the written vernacular was recognized as a proper literary medium by the Chinese literati until the beginning of the twentieth century. In spite of the distinctions that separated these literatures in China, there was a complex interaction between them, marked by a general upward flow of subject-matter from one to the other.¹

In the Chosŏn period of Korea, there existed a set of conditions that tended to separate popular culture from the orthodox culture of the society. The higher culture of traditional Korea based its institutions on Chinese models and consciously shunned the popular culture as a source of artistic

inspiration; there was no upward flow of literary materials and only piecemeal borrowing from the higher culture by the popular culture. Chinese Neo-Confucianism dominated the philosophy and aesthetics of the former, while Buddhism and indigenous shamanism invested the latter; the literature of the former was written, while that of the latter was oral; the literary language of the former was mainly Chinese, while that of the latter was Korean. Along with Korea's hereditary class standings and professions, these conditions made for a dual cultural tradition in Korea, assuring the survival of the oral narrative, which thrived in the context of the popular culture until the twentieth century, when it was absorbed by the written literary tradition of the society.

The kwangdae had no occupation (such as farming) other than the performance of oral narratives. His training was lengthy, specialized, and rigorous. He was born into the lowest of social classes, grew up in poverty, banded together with others of his profession, and had an ambiguous social status and access that varied with his skill, popularity, and patronage. This professional singer of tales survived by dint of his wit and eloquence and, jealous of his art, regarded outsiders with suspicion and kept any written texts a secret. He developed his lengthy songs during performance and had to think quickly under these conditions, improvising rapidly and fluently to satisfy his audience.

Hwarang Tradition and Shaman Culture

The earliest identifiable predecessors of the kwangdae are usually sought amongst participants in the festivals of community and state. The history of state-sponsored performance in Korea dates back to the formative years of ancient society when the founding rulers were chief shamans in whom were combined both political and religious functions.² Before the introduction and subsequent success of Buddhism during the Shilla period, the religious life of the country was shamanistic and court entertainment reflected this native culture. Young members of the nobility sometimes played a religious role that included the performance of song and dance, as members of the aristocratic *hwarang* order. The order is said to have been established by King Chinhŭng (r. 534–576) in the last year of his reign for ethical, artistic, and military training.³ Young men were admitted to it at ages thirteen to fifteen and later graduated to serve the country as civil and military leaders.

Although the *hwarang* order may not itself have been a shaman insti-

tution nor its members themselves shamans, their activities basically reflected a native shamanistic outlook.⁴ The *hwarang* visited “celebrated” (probably sacred) mountains and rivers, where they sang and danced, praying for national peace and progress.⁵ This was consistent with the fact that the Council of Elders, the highest organ of the Shilla state, would retire to one of the four sacred mountains surrounding the capital when they had to discuss and decide questions of particular importance to the nation.⁶ The choice of mountain sites for prayer and debate by the *hwarang* and the elders was appropriate for the shamanistic context of early Shilla society and may be related to the ancient mountain worship found also in Japan and Mongolia.⁷

From its inception, the *hwarang* order continued to enjoy the personal interest and patronage of the king, who frequently exercised his right to name new members, selecting them from among the sons of the high nobility. At least one king, Kyöngmun (r. 861–875), was himself a *hwarang* in his youth, having joined the order at the age of eighteen.⁸

Chinhüŋ, the king who first sanctioned the *hwarang* order, also instituted an annual court entertainment, the *p'algwanhoe*, at which members of the *hwarang* order performed.⁹ This celebration, held in the palace gardens, was a formalization of the annual and semi-annual custom of heaven-worship, which had been observed by primitive Koreans and has survived today in remote country villages in the form of periodic festivals such as the mask play at Hahoe. According to Hong Pong-han's encyclopedic *Tongguk munhön pigo* (Collected Korean documents; 1770), participants “amused themselves with singing, dancing, and variety acts and, also, prayed for blessings.”¹⁰

At their height, the *hwarang* had enjoyed high popular regard; but, toward the end of the Shilla period, their status gradually declined. With the coming of the Koryö period, there was no longer a place for them in the official order of things; they lost their political base and the path to power that their order had afforded them. The decline of the *hwarang* was probably related to the disintegration of the royal establishment, rise of the local nobility, and concomitant philosophical transformation that characterized the late-Shilla period. The *hwarang* exemplified the warrior ideal and native beliefs that had built the state and assured its social order. But now a much different philosophy was on the rise, influenced by Chinese thought and espoused by non-royal nobility. Oral culture was giving way to the written as lords of the word were yielding to those of the letter, for it was descendants of the lettered nobles of Shilla who would eventually assume political leadership in the coming Koryö period.¹¹

Modern Korean scholarship assumes that this degraded *hwarang* tradition merged with other shamanistic aspects of the popular culture during the Koryŏ period.¹² In the shadow of a Koryŏ state policy favoring Buddhism, the *hwarang* became displaced and dispersed; and their religious activity took on the form of popular shamanistic rituals. Their martial skills were turned to tumbling, acrobatics, and rope-walking; and their music became accompaniment for shaman ritual or the stuff of itinerant band performances. Furthermore, after the establishment in the middle tenth century of the Koryŏ examination system and the subsequent growth of a bureaucratic class with no less a status than the noble officialdom of Shilla, the scattered *hwarang* were demeaned as a group of wandering outcasts who were unregistered and difficult to control, reminiscent of Europe's Gypsies.

Although the social status of actors, singers, musicians, dancers, and other entertainers had thus declined to that of a degraded minority, there was still a demand for their services at court that was to increase over the years of the Koryŏ period. There were three major periodic events that took place in the Koryŏ court over the course of a year: the *p'algwanhoe* mentioned above, the *yŏndŭnghoe*, and *narye*. They were like state religious rites that were meant to assure national peace and prevent disaster through song and dance. The *p'algwanhoe*, dating back to the Shilla period, sought national peace through prayers addressed to mountain and river spirits; the *yŏndŭnghoe*, introduced during Koryŏ, sought the blessings of Buddha; and the *narye*, instituted in early Koryŏ and influenced by Chinese models, served as the annual exorcism of the court. Though of differing religious import, all three events were performed on the same sort of large, festooned stage and shared a common core of secular songs, dances, acrobatic feats, and variety acts.¹³

The founding king of Koryŏ, T'aejo (r. 918–935), revived the Shilla *p'algwanhoe* for his court, where it was held in the eleventh lunar month. This Koryŏ version of the Shilla *p'algwanhoe* preserved some parts of its predecessor, particularly a section called *sasŏn akpu* (music troupe of the four *hwarang*), which was dominated by the music, singing, and dancing of *hwarang*. Although its actual content is not clearly understood, Lee Duhyŏn stresses, "The expression *sasŏn akpu* was not related only to dancing in a narrow sense; but, rather, we should see the term as associated with the totality of the song, music, and dance—in the broad sense—that had been the responsibility of the *hwarang* order."¹⁴

Many professional actors and entertainers—apart from musicians—were attached to the Koryŏ court (160 people at one point) with exclusive re-

sponsibility for theatrical events. And, in addition to these court entertainers, there were also many entertainers and musicians throughout the country, living in the midst of a populace that appeared to have sufficient resources to support them as professionals.¹⁵

Although an attempt was made under Söngjong (r. 982–997) to eliminate the *p'algwanhoe* on grounds that it incorporated “inappropriate and annoying, motley amusements,” foreshadowing comparable attitudes of the Chosön period, it was soon revived and went on to flourish well into the twelfth century. As the *hwarang*, who had maintained the *p'algwanhoe* tradition, began to disappear in the twelfth century, aristocrats and rich people took over its management, with the result that it gradually became secularized and its once-dominant religious aspect was reduced to a side event accompanying a show composed of worldly variety acts. The *p'algwanhoe* declined during the thirteenth century and had disappeared from court life by the reign of Wönjong (r. 1260–1274).¹⁶

I infer from two descriptive poems¹⁷ by the late-Koryö scholar Yi Saek (Mogün, 1328–1396) that variety entertainment at court by the fourteenth century was called *sandae chapkük* (stage theatricals), as distinguished from the exorcistic *narye* rituals. The late-Koryö expression *sandae*, meaning an elevated platform, here replaced the earlier and more descriptive designation, *ch'aebung*, which had meant a stage draped with silk. The term *sandae* became more commonly used during the Chosön period, when court entertainments were generally known as *sandaehüi* (stage play).¹⁸

After 1392, the new Chosön government rejected Buddhism and adopted Confucianism as the state ethic. Subsequently, Buddhist monks were relegated to a station similar to that of the *hwarang*. But the Buddhists still had their temples in the mountains, the protection of tradition and popular belief, and an income of sacrificial rice and offerings with which they were able to survive. The *hwarang*, however, were left with no such means and had no choice but to tour and perform their songs and participate in shamanistic rituals. Some built shrines in various localities for shaman worship and restricted their activities to a district surrounding the shrine. While the women conducted rituals, the men assisted by providing a musical accompaniment. As a regular relationship developed with their believers, they managed to get along on the money and grain received for their rituals, prayers, and fortune-telling.¹⁹ This shaman “parish” system, called the *tangol* system, is common today in Chölla and Kyöngsang Provinces. It is centered on a hereditary shaman who, carrying on priestly authority passed through the generations, is not spiritually possessed but has been ordained

by human agency. This type of shaman functions within a systematic institutional structure and exercises jurisdiction over a fixed territory.²⁰

The men had several specialties and were grouped into three classifications: instrumentalists, called *agin* or *kongin*, who played flute and drum; physical performers, called *chaein*, who did tumbling, rope-walking, and acrobatics; and singers, called *kwangdae*. All three were commonly lumped together as *chaein* or *kwangdae*. As a matter of natural evolution, the husband of a shaman, who had served as accompanist and assistant to his wife, eventually emerged as a professional actor or singer on his own. The set of skills he already possessed were easily transferred to a secular context.

A continuous stream of comments—frequently demeaning and abusive—from private and official sources throughout the Chosŏn period makes it clear that such lowborn entertainers as these successors to the *hwarang* were destined to remain relegated to a status determined by their social, cultural, and economic circumstances until those circumstances finally began to change with the coming of the twentieth century.

A modern study of *tan'gol* shamans allows some glimpses of these years of change and also documents the presence of male p'ansori singers in *tan'gol* shaman family lineages.²¹ Three families were examined in considerable detail for the personal background of the primary shaman, family structure and lineage, ritual practices, and ritual texts. The lineages, of which two were interrelated, covered from four to six generations and the earliest birth date that can be inferred would have been about 1840 (from a daughter given as born in 1856). In all, fifteen women and nineteen men were clearly accounted for by name, age, and occupational specialty.

It is clear that the women had little choice but to be shamans, except for two young women who were identified as “popular singers,” an occupation consistent with their backgrounds. The name of one of the popular singers was withheld from the report. The men, however, had a variety of specialties including *tan'gol* shaman, p'ansori singer (both nineteenth-century and contemporary), musician (zither, flute, drum), tumbler, shrine helper, businessman, and college dropout. The name of one of the p'ansori singers (a registered Intangible Cultural Treasure at the time) was withheld; the businessman's company name was not given; and the college dropout, who had previously done some shaman duties, had a “pessimistic view towards having been born into a *tan'gol* shaman family.”²²

The 1969 report describes a modern shaman culture that looks essentially the same as its early-Chosŏn antecedent, as reconstructed in modern Korean scholarship. In both cases, we find a socially outcast, hereditary

profession that is organized on a territorial basis. While the women are virtually all practicing shamans, the men have a variety of specialties, chief among which is musician-accompanist. Useful in the context of this present study is the fact that the men are also frequently active as variety entertainers.

The Chosŏn Court and Its Popular Entertainers

Although Chosŏn officials had no interest in popular culture, they did have a use for popular entertainers. As was the case in earlier periods, the Chosŏn court sponsored periodic and occasional entertainments for which they employed such variety performers as masked dancers, musicians, singers, jugglers, rope-walkers, acrobats, tumblers, magicians, comedians, and puppeteers. The Chosŏn court and aristocracy served as an unintentional catalyst in the transformation of folk entertainments into extended and refined works of oral narrative, playing a role not unlike that of the feudal domains and religious establishments of medieval Japan in the development of Japanese narrative literature.²³ Unlike China and Japan, however, Korea had neither great urban centers with a monied mercantile class that would support professional theater nor sufficient sources of aristocratic protection and patronage in the countryside to nurture a class of itinerant entertainers.

Korea did develop a practical and necessary system of linkage involving the royal court, local officialdom, literati, and rural entertainers.²⁴ Through this mechanism, which developed during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, erstwhile outcast singers and actors came to perform in the capital, gain access to forbidden precincts of the palace, absorb elements of aristocratic literary culture, compete with their colleagues, and exchange materials with performers from other parts of the country. Thus, the professional singer of tales, the kwangdae, was able to gain exposure to the lettered world. Eventually, seminal performers of the p'ansori oral narrative emerged and populated the nineteenth and twentieth centuries with their artistic progeny.

While the Chosŏn court eliminated the Koryŏ *p'algwanhoe* and *yŏn-dŭnghoe*, they did continue the *sandaehŭi* variety show and the exorcistic *narye*, which became known as *naryehŭi* (exorcism and plays). The *naryehŭi*, held on the last day of the twelfth lunar month, still served to exorcize malevolent spirits; and the *sandaehŭi*, performed on its decorated stage, was held on such occasions as days of national celebration. Both the *sandaehŭi*

and *naryehŭi* provided professional entertainers with continuing opportunities to perform in the capital city. The two events overlapped in content and personnel and, indeed, eventually became confused with each other.

The *naryehŭi* got its name from the fact that its program customarily consisted of an exorcism (*narye*) followed by various entertaining plays (*hŭi*), which actually involved all kinds of singing, dancing, acrobatics, and witty talk. These plays and their performers were the same as those employed in *sandaehŭi* variety shows. As a result of the fact that people paid more attention to performance than to function, the two events came to be grouped under the one term, *sandaehŭi*.²⁵ According to a notice in the *Munjong Shillok* for the sixth month of 1451, these *sandaehŭi* were divided into three aspects: acrobatic and spectacle shows, farces, and music.²⁶ The acrobatic and spectacle shows were made up of such stunts as rope-walking, juggling, and tumbling; the farces consisted of humorous talk; and the music included singing, dancing, and playing on instruments.²⁷

Sandaehŭi—particularly the farces—provided opportunities for quick-witted, improvisational performers to develop their technical skills as they encountered sophisticated and demanding audiences, lettered culture, and professional competition. In the capital, they worked in an artistically comprehensive context that would eventually support the development of an improvisational oral narrative literature that combined prose and poetry and was vocally demanding, full of musical and rhythmic variation, rich in gesture and characterization, structurally complex, witty and poignant, and abounding in audience give-and-take. For more than three hundred years, the *sandaehŭi* and other opportunities to perform in the capital provided an enriching complement to the boisterous cauldron of the rural marketplace theater and so, by the opening of the eighteenth century, a fully formed, extended oral narrative song—called *p'ansori*—began to appear and attract the attention of the lettered populace, who could document its existence.

Sandaehŭi were given on stages erected within court precincts or on the wayside as part of royal banquets and progresses, state receptions, various periodic festivals, and other occasional official observances.²⁸ The most ambitious *sandaehŭi* were held to mark the visit of Chinese embassies: large-scale performances were given not only at provincial centers along the route from the Chinese border, but also in the capital. In his “Ch’ao-hsien fu” (Rhymeprose on Chosŏn), the Chinese envoy Tung Yueh described a performance he had seen in Seoul when he visited in 1488 to announce the ascension of the Ming emperor, Hsiao Tsung.²⁹ According to Tung Yueh, this variety show, rather like a circus, included such acts as fire-eating,

dragon-dancing, children's dancing, tumbling, rope-walking, puppet shows, and grotesque mask-dancing. It was performed on a stage housed within a structure that he judged to be as high as the palace gates, which would have been about forty feet.

From the size and shape of the *sandaehŭi* stage, it appears that many of these productions were major undertakings, consuming great amounts of human and material resources.³⁰ More than just platforms, the stages were decorative objects in themselves. Though simple in the Koryŏ period, the stages of the Chosŏn period were painted, festooned, and decorated with portraits of historical and legendary figures. So heavy was the cost of building and decorating them that some kinds of expensive stages were eliminated at times and efforts were made to reuse others in following years.³¹ The government office responsible for such events was called the *Sandae togam* or *Narye togam* (a *togam* was an office set up to supervise a special event). While the *togam* staff, on temporary reassignment from other offices, handled planning and preparations, actual stage management of the production was left to the lowborn signers, actors, acrobats, and other itinerant entertainers—all conscripted to perform without compensation.³²

For most of these performers, life was a harsh affair, lived from day to day, hand to mouth. Remarks appear in the *Shillok* from time to time, noting that they did not farm but begged for food or that they even turned to thievery when they could not otherwise survive, since their livelihoods depended totally on performing.³³ A *Shillok* entry for 1481 notes that performers also banded together to give performances.³⁴ Their usual audience, as impoverished as they, was found in farming and fishing villages, around temples and shrines, and in the periodic marketplaces. They were of the common people and reflected the tastes and sensibilities of that audience.³⁵ Therefore, a chance to perform in the capital was a golden opportunity that often attracted performers in sufficient numbers to disconcert court officials, some of whom already had a very low opinion of them.

Controlling these performers, particular the farce players, proved to be a challenge. The passage from the *Munjong Shillok* for the sixth month of 1451, quoted above, that divides *sandaehŭi* into spectacle, farce, and music, also reflects official attitudes toward the content and performers of farce. While recommending that both the music and spectacles be continued "as from days of yore," the passage singles out the farces as being acceptable only if they are "kept to a limited number."³⁶ But, although the farces were not essential to the *sandaehŭi*, they were nevertheless included because they

were the strong suit of the performers who were themselves essential to all aspects of *sandaehŭi*.³⁷

Since these farces could not be eliminated, they became the subject of ongoing debate within the government. Those Confucian officials who argued against the retention of old practices and in favor of a whole new order based on Neo-Confucianism also took the *sandaehŭi* for their whipping boy because of their particular distaste for farce plays. The debate lasted as long as *sandaehŭi* itself.

While the entertainers were needed at court, they were still despised for their rustic vulgarity. Indeed, these rowdy country folk were the very antithesis of what many members of the Confucian establishment regarded as civilized. A minister of King Myŏngjong (r. 1545–1567) asked in 1561, “How can we call this a civilized state and yet have these plays of puppets and actors?” Arguing against making such plays a part of formal court events, particularly in the forbidden precincts, the same minister summed up, “These plays are, all of them, the vulgar and ragged affairs of the streets and villages.”³⁸

Court officials were especially displeased with the popular reaction to *sandaehŭi* performers, who would attract swarms of onlookers at their public performances in Seoul. The presence of women and students in the crowds, in particular, aroused their ire.³⁹ The Inspector General in 1431, Shin Kae, submitted a memorial which condemned the *sandaehŭi* for its bad influence on the morals of women and asked that they be kept away, saying, “It would be most unfortunate if we do not succeed in reforming these evil customs and rectifying the way of women.”⁴⁰ King Sejong (r. 1418–1450), however, did not approve the memorial. The performers appear to have continued to be very popular among women; for another Inspector General reported to the throne in 1537, “Recently women gather in vacant houses to see the plays of actors. They say there are also such occurrences even within the palace.”⁴¹

A prohibition against aristocratic women attending welcoming ceremonies for the 1606 Ming embassy was recorded in the *Shillok*: “On the day when customary ceremonies are held to welcome the Chinese embassy, aristocratic women of the capital take in the sight. Their mule-litters stretch in lines and their adornment and cosmetics cause confusion. The Third Royal Secretary was told that, on the day of welcome for the Chinese embassy, there would be a strict curfew imposed on the families of aristocrats with the head of household held responsible.”⁴²

In 1703, a prohibition was applied to students when King Sukchong (r.

1674–1720) approved a request from the headmaster of the National Academy that “students discovered watching the *sandaehŭi* be kept from sitting for state examinations for a period of three years.” In making his request, the headmaster reported, “The capital is thrown into chaos at the time of a *sandaehŭi* performance; noisy arguments erupt and every place is in confusion. I have seen, in this midst, the evil of many students getting into fights and knocking people down!”⁴³

Sandaehŭi performances ceased by the end of the eighteenth century.⁴⁴ The heavy cost of preparations may have helped bring about the end of large-scale government patronage; for the record is dotted with notices suggesting preparations on a smaller scale, saving materials for reuse on later occasions, and other measures to reduce expenses.⁴⁵ By the time that the noted octogenarian scholar of the New Learning School, Yi Ik (Sŏngho, 1681–1763), was writing his *Sŏngho sasŏl* (Sŏngho’s jottings) in the middle of the eighteenth century, the *sandaehŭi* had become a major expense. In the opinion of Yi Ik, the court would be well rid of this waste of money that served only to “dissipate the mind.” In *Sŏngho sasŏl* he makes the following comments: “First there was wastefulness and then it became excessive, flowing over to harm the people and even disrupt the world. Why do these things continue unabated? In the present age an office was specially established to build stages of the left and right each time a Chinese embassy came. The competitions were novel. Each time it grew bigger and the expense was great. Could this not be lessened each time and then finally be abolished?”⁴⁶

The *sandaehŭi* farces, which were so popular with the public and so disturbing to some members of the establishment, consisted of witty talk intended to evoke laughter. A single player could do a monologue of questions and answers, or several players could take individual roles. There is an early reference to this kind of farce, albeit *alfresco*, given in the *Koryŏ sa* (History of Koryŏ; 1451) and assigned to the reign of King Kongmin (r. 1352–1374). It is contained in a biography of the stern Koryŏ bureaucrat, Yŏm Hŭng-bang (d. 1388). According to this account, Yŏm Hŭng-bang was returning from a visit to relatives when he came upon a place where the street was packed with spectators watching a player do a scene in which the slave of a very powerful household is tormenting a commoner in order to collect tenant farm rent. Yŏm is said to have watched with amusement.⁴⁷ Not only does this anecdote help link Chosŏn-period farce to its Koryŏ antecedents, but it also reminds us of the social function of farce and of its origins among the common people.

While the kings and nobles of Koryŏ openly enjoyed their court entertainments, even to the extent of participating themselves, their straight-laced Chosŏn counterparts customarily sat motionless, only watching and listening, no matter what was being performed. Nevertheless, there were times when even a Chosŏn monarch would have a farce player called in for unofficial diversion to relieve tedium. But a pretext was needed to justify letting the king listen to what was regarded as utter nonsense from a lowborn clown, hence the almost ubiquitous endnotes added to documentary accounts of farces performed in the royal presence to the effect that the king lent an ear to farces in order to hear things that would help him grasp the sentiment of the people and, thus, better rule the country.⁴⁸

But the king was not alone in having a hidden agenda. Just as he sought amusement in the guise of grasping popular sentiment, so the farce player, for his part, sought to plead the people's case in the guise of performing nonsensical farce. All the while, the player knew well that he risked punishment as payment for his efforts.

The Yŏnsan'gun (r. 1495–1506) seems to have been easily irked by incautious farce players. When a player named Konggyŏl in the twelfth month of 1499 ridiculed the Confucian classic canon in several particulars, he was declared insolent, lashed, and expelled to work as a post-station attendant.⁴⁹ And, in the twelfth month of 1504, a player named Konggil was beaten and banished for presenting a farce in which he said that it is difficult to find an ideal king but that splendid ministers always abound. The wretched Konggil had the courage to remonstrate against the tyrannical Yŏnsan'gun when no one else dared to speak!

Two stories in *P'aegwan chapki* (A collector's miscellany) by Ŏ Suk-kwŏn (fl. 1525–1554) demonstrate that farce players on occasion could achieve redress for the people. The first story regards a heavy cloth tax the government had been levying on shamans in particular. When tax collectors appeared at the shaman's gate, shouting and carrying on, the entire household would hastily prepare food and wine to receive them and then beg for a postponement. Such encounters could stretch on for days. When a player took one of these incidents and, fashioning it into a farce, performed it in the courtyard of the palace, the king listened and had the discriminatory shaman cloth tax abolished. Since the player would have come from or been closely connected to a shaman family, he could perform on the basis of detailed knowledge. According to Ŏ Suk-kwŏn's account, the actors "preserved this play and still perform it to this day,"⁵⁰ suggesting that farce plays were not necessarily always newly improvised at the time of their

performance and that they enjoyed some measure of lasting popularity among the common people.⁵¹

While this farce satirized an institutional practice that needed correction, other farces were directed at specific corrupt or covetous officials whose behavior was eventually rectified as a direct result of the farce players' efforts, such as the case of Ku Se-jang, magistrate of Chǒngp'yǒng in the reign of Chungjong (r. 1506–1544). Ō Suk-kwōn tells how actors one New Year's day performed a play for the king in which this greedy magistrate haggled tyrannously with a saddle dealer and finally bought himself a saddle with government money. The king, hearing this, ordered the magistrate arrested, flogged, and punished for misappropriation of funds. "Indeed," concludes Ō Suk-kwōn, "the actors could impeach a corrupt official!"⁵²

Players on Their Own

Reports of individual farce players, performing at court or before the king, disappear from official records and private writings in the early seventeenth century.⁵³ Nevertheless, *sandaehŭi* continue to be performed at court and court records reflect that unnamed *sandaehŭi* performers continue to raise official ire. Here, however, a new emphasis appears: officials are now also criticizing entrepreneurial public performances outside the province of court *sandaehŭi*. I do not know what became of the role that farce players performed at court but, on the basis of their popular following and the hereditary nature of their calling, I assume that they continued their professional activity. Presumably they were attracted by opportunities to continue performing, for compensation, in other, undocumented contexts. Indeed, this moment, when farce plays and their players no longer evoke comment in the court record or other, private sources, coincides with early stages of the development of commerce and the growth of private capital among commoners, which made it increasingly possible for entertainers to make a living by selling their talents among the common people.

The seventeenth century in Korea set the scene for the prosperous eighteenth, when aristocratic intellectuals were to explore new ways of thought and popular culture would enjoy an awakening. Economic developments of the seventeenth century served to create new wealth in non-aristocratic hands. New agricultural technology enriched enterprising peasant farmers, and changing tax laws permitted the emergence of powerful wholesale merchants. While shops appeared in Seoul and periodic markets developed in

the countryside (where entertainers could gather their audiences), rural brokers and itinerant peddlers grew in number. Middlemen began to offer support services to merchants, ranging from warehousing to banking.⁵⁴

In such an environment, the newly rising commoners were increasingly able to purchase the services of professional entertainers and thereby provide them with both employment and a new kind of audience. Popular entertainment, thitherto, had been presented basically in two very contrasting environments: farming and fishing villages, on the one hand, and the royal court and mansions of the aristocracy, on the other. However, this third, urban audience did not record its culture as fully as did the court and aristocracy and, therefore, left an incomplete record of the popular entertainment they enjoyed.

In addition to performing within the palace, out-of-doors on a stage, or as party to a royal progress, entertainers, called “kwangdae” also served in the entourages of the aristocracy and guests of the court in the capital city, literally dancing attendance upon the central figure in the procession. As early as the eighteenth century, performers were attending successful state examination candidates on their triumphal tours of celebration. In his *Sŏngho sasŏl*, Yi Ik observes, “Nowadays the successful examination candidate must have a player to make music.”⁵⁵ A generation later, Yu Tŭk-kong (1748–1807) gives a more detailed account of this custom in his *Kyŏngdo chapki* (Capital miscellany): “The successful examination candidate receives his diploma and goes in a procession with musicians, kwangdae, and acrobats in attendance. A kwangdae is a player who wears brocade robes and a yellow straw hat in which are stuck silk flowers and peacock feathers. He dances a vigorous dance and makes merry patter. The acrobat does rope-walking, tumbling, and performs various turns.”⁵⁶

This custom of performers’ attending a new licentiate continued into the nineteenth century. In “Hanyang ka” (Song of the capital), a lengthy narrative poem in the *kasa* form, an anonymous poet with the pen name Hansan Kōsa described the scene as he saw it in 1844. Dancers greeted the celebrants as they emerged from the palace and formed a grand retinue that paraded through the streets:

Amidst the flowers and the willows,
Music at a quick-beat followed;
Dancers dancing, servants calling—
Sound reverberating everywhere.⁵⁷

The early modern scholar Ch'oe Nam-sŏn (1890–1957) has described these triumphal tours as he knew them at the turn of the twentieth century. A central event in the celebration of a new licentiate was the *yuga* procession, a three-day tour through the streets of the capital with stops to call upon examination officials, older licentiates, and relatives. This was followed by a visit to the licentiate's home village to honor his parents, sacrifice to his ancestors, and hold banquets. Ch'oe Nam-sŏn concludes, "In the *yuga* procession, singing actors lead the way, displaying their skills. At every banquet or sacrifice, such publicly performed music and entertainment is necessarily included."⁵⁸

The poet Song Man-jae (1788–1851) refers to an interesting aspect of this practice of attending the licentiate in his Chinese poem, "Kwanuhŭi" (On seeing the plays of actors; 1843), in which he describes a variety entertainment by musicians, actors, singers, and tumblers. One of his allusive stanzas reads:

With diploma given, they chant the *tŏktam*
 Of soaring rank and ambition won—
 From Secretariat Recorder to State Councilor:
 One leap to the sweet realm of an Acacia Dream.⁵⁹

This refers to the practice of a kwangdae's returning with the new licentiate to his home and there conducting rites to ensure the young man's future success. Drawing upon the testimony of one famous drummer to kwangdae, Han Sŏng-jun (1875–1935), Yi Hye-gu gives the following account of this ritual, which is called a *tŏktam*:

When the licentiate, accompanied by a kwangdae, reaches his country home, the kwangdae sets a table in the garden and places rice on top of it. On top of the rice he places the diploma and then intones rites. These consist of a summary of history since the Creation, of the Three Kingdoms, and of the Koryŏ and Yi dynasties. Then he chants, describing the furnishings of the house, speaking of the new licentiate, and asking that they be blessed with wealth and rank in the future.⁶⁰

To this, Yi Hye-gu adds that *tŏktam* is another word for *kosa* (a ritual offering to spirits for good fortune). He goes on to remark that, in a radio broadcast made prior to the Second World War, one Pang Ŭng-gyo⁶¹ said that the *tŏktam* was sung in the *chung mori* rhythm from beginning to end. In

view of this, Yi Hye-gu concludes, "We can see a relationship between p'ansori and shaman ritual."⁶² Yi Hye-gu's conclusion is based upon the fact that the *chung mori* rhythm, which is fundamental to p'ansori, is also heard in this shaman ritual for the licentiate and his family.

This *töktam* is recorded by the ethnographers Akamatsu Chijō and Akiba Takashi in their study on Korean shamanism as part of a widespread shaman ceremony called *ch'önshin kut* (rite for offering first produce to god), which was performed annually to celebrate the first of a new crop.⁶³ The *töktam* occurs in a section of the ceremony called the *Ch'angbu*, named for the *ch'angbu* song which the shaman sings at that point in the proceedings. *Ch'angbu* designates the husband of a shaman. The rendering that Akamatsu and Akiba give of this *ch'angbu* song and its incorporated *töktam* appears to be a narration of the same ceremony which the drummer Han Söng-jun described to Yi Hye-gu.⁶⁴

According to the drummer Han, the state examinations in Seoul also provided the assembled kwangdae a parallel opportunity to hold their own formal, competitive examination. Singers would gather in the reception hall of some high government official and there compete for recognition on the basis of their talent. The winners would then be engaged by the new licentiates and given generous rewards of silk and other gifts, being enriched to the degree of their standing in the competitions.⁶⁵

2

The Kwangdae's Nineteenth-Century Heyday

The evolution of p'ansori, like that of any art, is a process with no fixed beginning. Practical definitions must, in fact, work backward from attested nineteenth-century practices in order to define the form. Within that process, the first recognizable example is the so-called Manhwa text of the "Song of Ch'un-hyang," by Yu Chin-han (Manhwaje, 1711–1791), which was recorded in a document of 1754.¹ Its appearance at that time leads us to assume that the final stage of p'ansori's gestation belongs to the first half of the eighteenth century. Chŏng Pyŏng-hŏn chooses 1800 to mark the approximate end of the genre's formative period.² This year roughly coincides with the birth dates of early master singers. Some forty years later, when these singers were in their prime, Song Man-jae composed his historically valuable poem, "Kwanuhŭi," which describes p'ansori as part of a variety show.

Prior to the time Song Man-jae was writing, however, individual p'ansori kwangdae had already begun to take advantage of opportunities to per-

form separately from troupes of variety entertainers. Since p'ansori, unlike other forms of variety entertainment, was performed by a solo artist and could be a complete show unto itself, it was especially easy for p'ansori kwangdae to perform outside the troupes of which they had already become the star attractions. They could set up and entertain almost anywhere since all that it took was for the kwangdae to stand, the drummer to sit, the kwangdae to sing, and the drummer to handle the accompaniment while calling out encouragement.

There is a document that picks up these kwangdae at the end of the eighteenth century and chronicles many aspects of their personal and professional lives through the late nineteenth century: family, training, professional relationships, performances, special skills, personalities, romantic affairs, and patrons. This singular document is the 1940 book, *Chosŏn ch'anggŭk sa* (History of Korean singing drama), in which the scholar-aficionado Chŏng No-shik records the reminiscences of p'ansori kwangdae who had been born in the last half of the nineteenth century and whom he interviewed in the 1930s. Although the title of Chŏng's book uses the term *ch'anggŭk*, which designates the popular twentieth-century ensemble performance of p'ansori, the book is actually a history of the nineteenth-century solo performers of p'ansori.

Though not a professional kwangdae himself, Chŏng spent some three years traveling around the country to interview as many performers as possible. His history contains eighty-nine individual biographies and was facilitated by the kwangdae tradition of orally transmitting their professional genealogies. He quotes the kwangdae Chŏn To-sŏng (b. 1863) on this tradition: "When I was young I visited performances of the famous singers Pak Man-sun, Yi Nal-ch'i, and others, where I heard them recite the names of great performers of the past in order."³ The master-disciple relationship, which served to transmit much of the wording and interpretation of the repertoire, also provided the kwangdae with a way of preserving a detailed oral history of their art and of their predecessors.

Five Professional Generations

Drawing upon this oral tradition, Chŏng was able to include in each biography both the place and date of the kwangdae's birth, as well as information about his professional relationships, such as the names of his teachers, seniors, colleagues, juniors, and students. The resulting large body of infor-

mation is entirely free of internal inconsistencies such as contradictions which might describe two singers as colleagues in one biography but as senior and junior in another. The historical scheme that emerges from these facts provides our first inkling of the stages of development that p'ansori passed through during the nineteenth century.

The period between the late eighteenth century and the early twentieth century (when Chŏng conducted his study) may be divided into five professional generations of kwangdae, all linked in a matrix of master-disciple relationships: 1) late eighteenth century, 2) early nineteenth century, 3) middle nineteenth century, 4) late nineteenth century, and 5) early twentieth century. Within each of these five generations there were a number of colleague groups. Each group was made up of kwangdae who regarded each other as strictly contemporary. Any such colleague group, therefore, was distinguished from another such group of the same generation by their relative seniority. On the whole, one generation of kwangdae generally served as teachers to the next.

The first generation, which flourished in the late eighteenth century (and into the early nineteenth), is known for a few, nearly legendary, figures who were thought of as the progenitors of the nineteenth-century p'ansori tradition. All modern histories of p'ansori start with reference to the shadowy Ha Han-dam (also known as Ha Ŭn-dam) and Ch'oe Sŏn-dal, with whose names the oral genealogies typically begin.⁴ Only one concrete and detailed personal history of a member of the founding generation survived in the oral record until Chŏng No-shik's day. This describes Kwŏn Sam-dŭk (1771–1841), a kwangdae of aristocratic origins and therefore called a *pigabi* (outsider) in the argot of the profession. While his family was closer to rural gentry than high aristocracy, they were, nevertheless, at one time about to execute him for having taken up such a dishonorable calling. But they settled for expelling him and having his name expunged from the clan records. This incident suggests that considerable changes must have taken place in the once-disdained art of p'ansori, generating an appeal that was compelling enough to entice such *pigabi* kwangdae as Kwŏn Sam-dŭk.

The second generation of kwangdae was larger, and their accomplishments are better known. Four of its master singers—Ko Su-gwan (b. ca. 1800), Song Hŭng-nok (b. ca. 1790), Yŏm Kye-dal (b. ca. 1800), and Mo Hŭng-gap (b. ca. 1800)—are celebrated in one line of a poem by the poet-official Shin Wi (1769–1847), “Kwan'gŭkshi chŏlgu” (Quatrains upon seeing a dramatic poem; 1826): “Ko, Song, Yŏm, and Mo—the talents of a generation!” The dating of this poem provides a valuable basis for estimating their

birth dates.⁵ In view of the fact that only Song Hŭng-nok came from the p'ansori heartland of Chŏlla Province and the three others were from Ch'ungch'ŏng and Kyŏnggi, we can confirm a spread of p'ansori into the central regions of the country in the early decades of the nineteenth century.⁶

When members of this second generation matured as singers and became masters of their art, they naturally attracted the following of younger and would-be kwangdae who sought them out as models and teachers. In this process, two schools of performance developed during the first half of the nineteenth century as disciples gathered around Song Hŭng-nok and Pak Yu-jŏn (b. 1834), in particular, and adopted their styles, which reflected the regional characteristics of the two master singers. The two schools, Song's *Tongp'yŏn-je* (Eastern school) and Pak's *Sŏp'yŏn-je* (Western school), were each named after the location of the leader's home, relative to the Sŏmjin River that runs south through Chŏlla Province.⁷

As opportunities to perform multiplied, the better kwangdae moved out of the marketplace and into the salons of the rich and powerful, who came to dote upon their favorite singers. The governor of Taegu once praised Song Hŭng-nok as the "King of Song" and King Hŏnjong (r. 1835–1849) rewarded Yŏm Kye-dal for his talents with an appointment to the rank of *tongji*, an honorary Fourth Minister. Chŏng No-shik's biographies reveal that kwangdae of the early nineteenth century were already flaunting the prestige that came with such notoriety as they rode about in sedan chairs, were treated to sumptuous meals, and stood out as popular personalities for whom *kisaeng* vied as lovers.

The third generation, a teaching generation, flourished in the middle third of the century. These teachers established classical interpretations and populated the remainder of the century with their disciples. During the dominance of the third generation, kwangdae contributed new episodes to old songs and also created entirely new works to bring their common repertoire to twelve songs. Since each singer would perform a song in his own individual manner, for which he became famous, new versions of established works were easily generated. The task of revision and refinement was not carried out by just the kwangdae alone. They had the help of educated men of letters. Chŏng No-shik reports, for example, that the kwangdae Pang Man-ch'un (fl. ca. 1830), who was of the same generation as Song Hŭng-nok and Yŏm Kye-dal, worked at length with a "man of letters who was a master of music and poetics" in Hwanghae Province (Pang's second home)

to revise and embellish earlier versions of the “Song of the Red Cliff” and “Song of Shim Ch’öng.” Their rough draft of the “Song of the Red Cliff” had been passed around and read by so many people that it was nearly in tatters.⁸

The fourth generation dominated the last third of the nineteenth century, producing students who maintained the classical tradition. They and their students also took part in the operatic adaptation of p’ansori, the establishment of flourishing theaters in the capital, and the formation of provincial touring companies. In the same period, two important patrons of kwangdae emerged, who contributed to the development of the p’ansori art and to the acceptability of these performers as entertainers to polite society. One of these was a rich petty official from the countryside, Shin Chae-hyo (1812–1884), and the other was the father of King Kojong (r. 1863–1907), the Regent Taewön’gun (1820–1898). As a devotee of p’ansori, the Taewön’gun came to play a considerable role, which was carried on by his son.

Before he became regent for his minor son in 1863, the Taewön’gun had spent considerable time with members of the commoner, petty-official class and enjoyed their entertainments, central among which was p’ansori.⁹ With the patronage and frequent invitations of the regent, such kwangdae as Pak Man-sun (1830–1898) and Pak Yu-jön gained fame; and, while still members of the lowborn class, they were honored with official appointments and would travel frequently to the capital.

Shin Chae-hyo, as an outsider, made a significant contribution to the development of p’ansori in his patronage and training of kwangdae, consolidation and editing of extant textual materials, exposition of theory, and composition of p’ansori itself. From about 1867 until his death in 1884, Shin devoted himself thoroughly to p’ansori, both as scholar and patron. His activity exemplifies the interest of the commoner, petty-official class in the performance and development of p’ansori.¹⁰

The members of the fifth generation were born in the last decades of the nineteenth century and were to carry the p’ansori tradition into the twentieth century and recite to Chöng No-shik the oral history of their art. These singers, then, are the link to the present day, for it is they whom Koreans in their seventies can still remember hearing on the radio and seeing on the stage in the 1930s and 1940s when they were children.

It is evident from Chöng No-sik’s study that the craft of the kwangdae was mostly hereditary during the nineteenth century. The wide variety of family relationships among the kwangdae in Chöng’s sampling suggests that

he recorded only fragments of a widespread and ramified network of kinship ties. Many less famous members of kwangdae families are presumably not mentioned in his study.

A significant number of Chŏng's subjects are related to each other by blood or marriage (brother, brother-in-law, cousin, uncle, father, grandfather, and so forth). Those related constitute 27 percent of the total. Several more are either related to other, unnamed kwangdae, or began training at such an early age that such a relationship could be inferred (based on the fact that most of the 27 percent who were related also received their early training from such relatives as fathers and uncles). In addition to this evidence and the overall hereditary nature of occupation and social status during the Chosŏn period,¹¹ there is also the general tendency for vocations in the lower social classes to be hereditary on account of the lack of alternatives and the economic need to involve children productively in the family's work as early as possible. In the case of entertainers, the range of specialties within their craft allowed a place for all members of a family, regardless of age or native talent.¹² The Song family of kwangdae is a case in point. This very famous dynasty of singers dates from the great Song Hŭng-nok, who flourished at the beginning of the nineteenth century. Song Kwang-nok (1803–?), Song Hŭng-nok's brother, served his older brother as a drummer until he could train himself to perform as a kwangdae.¹³ Then he and a brother-in-law passed on the family tradition to their sons and grandsons (the grandsons were both alive when Chŏng conducted his study).¹⁴

Entertainers were frequently married to female shamans, who were of the same low social status.¹⁵ In the terminology of Korean shamanism, the musician-husband of a shaman was called a *ch'angbu* or *mubu*. He would serve as her accompanist on the drum and could also perform as a singer himself.¹⁶ In the *ch'angbu* song, mentioned above, we encountered a shaman narrative that describes these singers as individual performers in their own right, working outside a shamanistic milieu, who journeyed to the capital where they met new licentiates and then accompanied them home to perform sacrificial rites.

National Association of Performers

Another function of the husband, particularly in Chŏlla Province (the heartland of p'ansori where shamans were mostly women), was to run the local shaman association which was centered in a business office called the *shin*

ch'öng, *chaein ch'öng*, or *ch'angbu ch'öng*.¹⁷ The business office maintained a *sönsaeng an* (record of teachers), which was a "statement of the basic principles of the shaman organization with a roster of the names of their predecessors."¹⁸ This document was the focus of annual rites, funded by membership dues, that were celebrated as others might perform ancestor worship.

This office also appears to have linked the male performers with the government, for which they served as occasionally conscripted entertainers. Among documents of the Kyönggi Province *chaein ch'öng*, uncovered by the ethnographers Akamatsu and Akiba, is an introduction to the office records, dated 1836, which notes that affiliates of the *chaein ch'öng* had "performed plays to the approbation of others on stages built at the time of foreign embassies to the country."¹⁹ We shall presently look at a memorial submitted to the government by eminent kwangdae of the same period which describes similar functions in similar terms.

Just before the Second World War, two unique and valuable documents came into the possession of the Vocal Music Research Society. The documents are known as the *Kapshin wanmun* (Kapshin disposition; 1824) and the *Chöngghae soji* (Chöngghae appeal; 1827).²⁰ Until then, scholars had been unaware of the existence, as early as the seventeenth century, of anything like a professional guild of entertainers.²¹ The *Kapshin wanmun*, submitted to the Board of Taxation by seven eminent performers, proposed the reorganization of their national association, then called "Chaein of the Eight Provinces" (the term *chaein* here was a general designation for variety performers of all specialties and degrees of skill). According to the introductory portion of the text, a national association of experienced performers had been established "after the Manchu Invasion [1636]" as a result of a meeting held in Seoul to which responsible delegates were sent from throughout the country. Although the organization continued to function through the end of the nineteenth century, we learn that large-scale pageants in Seoul were discontinued in the late eighteenth century: "Stages of the left and right were not erected for performance after the year of *kapchin* [1784]."

In the *Kapshin wanmun*, the performers propose that the *chaein* of each province keep a branch office of the association in readiness to eliminate the need for special orders and also to avoid the disorderly convergence of performers in Seoul on the occasion of the arrival of a Chinese embassy. The text states that leadership of the organization was vested primarily in men from the three provinces of Kyönggi, Ch'ungch'öng, and Chölla, with lesser representation from Kyöngsang and Kangwön. The three northern provinces were grouped as one in their administrative structure.

Yi Chong-man, who had served as a provincial assistant director in 1908, described the structure as he knew it to Akamatsu and Akiba in 1938:

The *chaein ch'öng* is also called *kwangdae ch'öng* or *hwarang ch'öng*. There is one in each *kun* of the three provinces of Kyönggi, Ch'ungch'öng, and Chölla. In each province the director is called *taebang*. Under each director are two assistant directors, one for the left province (*chwado tosanju*) and one for the right province (*udo tosanju*). One province is divided into left and right as a matter of jurisdictional form. A *tosanju* assists the *taebang*, and it is his task to deliberate with him on important matters. Under each assistant director, there are four stewards (*chipkang*), four secretaries (*kongwön*), and two clerks (*sangmu*). The stewards and secretaries manage affairs and the clerks do general administration. In contrast to this, the head of the *chaein ch'öng* in each *kun* is called a *ch'öngsu* and, under him, are a secretary and a clerk.²²

Kim Dong-uk has charted the organizational structure both as written in the *Kapshin wanmun* and as described by Yi Chong-man and found them to coincide.²³ In view of such long-term stability, it may well be that essentially the same structure had existed since the seventeenth century.

According to the *Kapshin wanmun*, each officer of the association was selected by consensus. And, once they were selected, other members of the association were expected to be obedient to them. In like manner, members were chosen by consensus to perform in Seoul. On the occasion of an embassy, in addition to giving a performance, they were always subordinate to the association, as on-call *kwangdae*, each waiting his turn to perform.

Corporate authority was symbolized by a seal, held by each local office, which was to be used on the official minutes of their deliberations. This seal was also essential for any petition made to the government. Its importance and usefulness are reflected in the 1827 *Chönghae soji*, presented by forty members of the Kongju *chaein* office to the local Office of Criminal Prosecution. In the document, they ask severe punishment of four musicians from Kongju who stole the office seal from its custodian, Song Il-mun of Ch'öngyang,²⁴ and used it to forward an unsanctioned document (which, unfortunately, has not been preserved).

Among the forty-seven names signed to the *Kapshin wanmun* and *Chönghae soji*, five also appear in Chöng No-sik's biographical sketches of noted *kwangdae*, suggesting that some of the leading p'ansori singers of the time were members of the *chaein* association when it was functioning. But, since Chöng presents his subjects as free agents and never mentions the associa-

tion, it is doubtful that the *chaein* group had much control over appearances of eminent performers at the capital or elsewhere. The singers of whom Chŏng writes seem to have received their invitations directly from their patrons. The *chaein* association, of which they appear to have been a leading element, was more likely concerned with lower-ranking entertainers, whose uncontrolled movement to the capital was reported to have created confusion.

We have seen that some p'ansori kwangdae, while every bit as lowborn as any rope-walker, tumbler, or other wandering entertainer, were able to gain special recognition which would let them leap over the hierarchical order of the status-based society of Chosŏn. Although this was due in part to their ability, based on arduous training, to sing erudite lyrics with refined melodies, there were social and economic changes during the nineteenth century that contributed to the remarkable mobility of prominent kwangdae like those who appear in Chŏng No-shik's book. In addition to the growth of commerce and the concentration of wealth in the hands of successful commoner merchants, which created a bourgeoisie, it is important to take note of increasing instability in the class system. With money or grain, anyone could get rank or buy lineage and become a yangban or aristocrat. The cash-hungry Chosŏn government had a schedule of prices for a variety of titles.²⁵ Whereas the population of Taegu, for example, was only 8.3 percent yangban in 1690, that figure had risen to 34.7 percent by 1789, and to 65.5 percent in 1858.²⁶

In such a climate, leading kwangdae enjoyed an entrée at court and in the homes of high officials and the rich and powerful. This privilege, enjoyed only at the pleasure of their patrons, may have been tenuous; but some prominent kwangdae were proud and haughty men whose remarkable talent gave them license to flaunt convention. Many were royal favorites and gave frequent command performances at court. Chŏng Ch'un-p'ung (fl. 1850), a great favorite of the Regent Taewŏn'gun, was a frequent visitor at the palace, "using the guest quarters like his personal bedroom."²⁷ Every ruler of the last half of the nineteenth century was entertained at court by kwangdae, and it was common for them to bestow title and rank on their favorites. One turn-of-the-century great, Song Man-gap, was successively named by King Sunjong as a *ch'ambong* (junior ninth grade position), a *kamch'al* (inspector), and a Royal Household Secret Inspector.

Patrons of the great kwangdae, in addition to kings and the Regent Taewŏn'gun, included ministers of state, provincial governors, military commanders, powerful politicians, and the landed rich. Some favored singers

adopted lifestyles as elevated as those of their patrons, not only affecting a formidable hauteur but also dressing with suitable elegance.

The famous kwangdae of the middle nineteenth century, Pak Man-sun, was one such remarkable entertainer. Chŏng No-shik relates an incident in which Pak Man-sun's arrogance toward the governor of Ch'ungch'ŏng Province might have led to his death had not his phenomenal talent turned away the wrath of that official, who was intent upon an execution.

When the Regent Taewŏn'gun once called Pak to Seoul for a performance, his route to the capital took him through Ch'ungch'ŏng, where the governor, Cho Pyŏng-shik, summoned him to perform. Pak refused.

"The Taewŏn'gun has called me to the capital for a command performance and I shall not open up until then," he responded and continued on to the capital, where he stayed several months to perform for the regent.

When it came time for him to return home, Pak told the regent of his refusal and begged for his life, claiming that he would surely be killed by the hot-tempered governor. After hearing the story, the regent ordered a personal letter sent to Governor Cho.

"To summarize in a few words, Pak's behavior merits execution and you may deal with him as you see fit. However, it would be best to listen once to his matchless p'ansori and then kill him."

Governor Cho realized that the regent's implication was against killing the singer and, relenting, asked for one p'ansori performance. Pak, rescued from the brink of death, did his very best with the result that he earned the protection of Governor Cho, it is said.²⁸